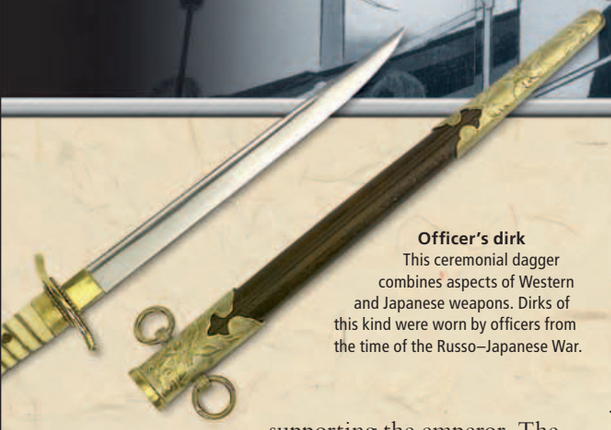




Officer's dirk
This ceremonial dagger combines aspects of Western and Japanese weapons. Dirks of this kind were worn by officers from the time of the Russo–Japanese War.

supporting the emperor. The foundations for a modern navy were laid after the establishment of a Navy Department in 1872, which set about creating Western-style naval dockyards, a naval academy, and an arsenal. At first Japan was totally dependent upon a transfer of technology and skills from the West. Britain's Royal Navy provided cadet training and British shipyards supplied most of Japan's early warships. The Japanese proved supremely good learners in naval as in other matters and the scope of their ambitions was soon apparent. In 1885 Japan took delivery of two steel cruisers that were the largest and most advanced vessels of their type in the world. By the 1890s Japanese shipyards had begun delivering home-built armored warships.

NAVAL POWER

The ethos of the new Imperial Japanese Navy was formed through a mix British influence—Japan's greatest admiral Togo Heihachiro consciously modeled himself upon Nelson—and of the samurai tradition of loyalty to the death. Japan was historically inclined to value its army far above its navy; only the Satsuma samurai clan had a naval tradition. But the defeat of China at sea in the Sino-Japanese war of 1894-95 raised the reputation of the Imperial Navy at home and abroad. Naval strength became the key to the acceptance of Japan as a major power on the world stage, in defiance of Western racial prejudice. The British, worried by the Royal Navy's inability to match combined French and Russian sea power in the Pacific, concluded a defensive alliance with Japan in January 1902. From Britain's point of view this was a practical solution to the problem of finding a Pacific naval ally. To the Japanese it was above all about achieving the right to respect as equals of the West.

Bolstered by the alliance with Britain, in 1904-05 Japan took on and beat the Russian Empire both on land and at sea—beginning the conflict with a surprise attack on Port Arthur without a declaration of war, an ominous prefigurement of Pearl Harbor in 1941. The Russo-Japanese War was a triumph for Japan and a proving ground for cutting-edge naval technology, at least on the Japanese side. The war showed the importance of wireless communications, possessed by the Japanese but not by the Russians. It showed the frightful potential of mines, which sunk battleships on both sides, and the possible uses of torpedo-firing destroyers. Above all, it showed the devastating effect of the latest naval guns with advanced fire control, delivering concentrated fire at long range with explosive shells.

The period of peace in Japan after 1905 saw cutbacks in naval spending, but even so the first Japanese-built dreadnought was launched in 1910 and bigger and better warships followed. The startling reversal of Japan's naval weakness of only half a century before was illustrated in World War I, when Japan was able to help out its overstretched ally Britain by sending destroyers to carry out anti-submarine duties in the Mediterranean. By then, however, potential conflicts of interest with Britain and the United States in the Pacific were already brewing.

WARSHIP TACTICS

CROSSING THE T

CONCENTRATING FIRE

The naval battles of the 1904-05 Russo-Japanese War demonstrated the new naval tactics of fleet encounters between steam-powered warships with their guns mounted in rotating turrets. As in the age of sail, ships entered battle in line astern and they might steam parallel to each other exchanging salvoes. However, the fleet with the faster warships could potentially maneuver to cross in front of the enemy line, bringing to bear enfilading fire (directed along the enemy line) from all the guns of its line simultaneously, while the enemy could only reply with its forward guns. The range of effective fire at this period was over 3 miles (5 km). The tactic, known in English as "crossing the T" and in Japanese as *tei sempo*, was a textbook ideal aspired to by naval commanders the world over, but it was rarely put into practice with complete success.

